

APAC Healthcare Sector M&A & Valuation Brief - 2026-07-26

APAC Healthcare Sector

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1. RECENT Healthcare M&A ACTIVITY

Today is a peaceful day, nothing big happened in the Consumer space.

2. MARKET DYNAMICS & SENTIMENT

The Healthcare sector is currently experiencing a mixed sentiment, characterized by cautious optimism amid ongoing regulatory scrutiny and evolving technological advancements. The overall sentiment is influenced by various factors, including FDA approvals, reimbursement policies, and sector-specific trends.

Subsector Breakdown:

- **Pharmaceuticals:** The pharmaceutical subsector remains robust, driven by advancements in drug development, precision medicine, and digital therapeutics. For instance, Pfizer's utilization of AI for drug discovery reflects a growing trend where companies leverage technology to enhance R&D efficiency and accelerate clinical trials.
- **Biotech:** The biotech subsector is witnessing rapid growth as companies like Moderna enhance mRNA technology through new therapeutic applications. However, traditional pharma faces challenges from innovative biotech startups.
- **Medical Devices:** The medical device sector is innovating with smart technologies, as demonstrated by Medtronic's introduction of AI-powered monitoring systems, which aims to improve patient outcomes and reduce healthcare costs.
- **Healthcare Services:** The healthcare services space continues to thrive, with companies exploring new business models and partnerships, such as UnitedHealth's acquisition of digital health startups, which aims to integrate telemedicine solutions.
- **Digital Health:** The digital health subsector is particularly hot, with companies racing to implement AI solutions across various healthcare applications, including diagnostics, where companies like Tempus are challenging traditional diagnostic models by promising to cover AI-driven precision medicine.

Key Market Drivers and Headwinds

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Drivers:

- **Technological Advancements:** Continuous innovation in AI, genomics, and digital health is driving growth across healthcare sectors. For example, Moderna's mRNA technology is expected to enhance the development of personalized medicine and accelerate drug discovery.
- **Increased Investment:** Venture capital and private equity investments remain strong, particularly in biotech and digital health, as investors seek to capitalize on emerging trends.

Headwinds:

- **Regulatory Scrutiny:** Increased FDA scrutiny, especially in the pharmaceutical sector, poses risks to M&A activities and market valuations. Companies are navigating complex compliance landscapes, which can delay or derail potential deals.
- **Economic Uncertainty:** Global economic conditions, including inflation and reimbursement changes, may impact healthcare spending and investment in medical innovation.

Subsector Performance Analysis

- **Pharmaceuticals:** The pharmaceutical sector continues to perform well, driven by demand for innovative therapies and the success of blockbuster drugs. Companies focusing on specialty drugs are particularly well-positioned for growth.
- **Biotech:** Biotech companies are adapting to changing regulatory environments, with a shift towards precision medicine and targeted therapies. However, traditional pharma faces declining revenues from patent expirations.
- **Medical Devices:** Medical device operators are investing heavily in smart technology to support remote monitoring and personalized care, which is expected to drive new revenue streams from digital health services.
- **Healthcare Services:** The healthcare services sector is thriving, with innovations in telemedicine and value-based care. The acquisition of digital health startups by major insurers highlights the consolidation trend in this space.
- **Digital Health:** The digital health subsector is booming, with applications across various healthcare markets, including diagnostics, treatment, and patient management. Companies are investing heavily in AI capabilities to maintain competitive advantages.

Trading Multiples Trends

Valuation Multiples: As of Q2 2025, the average EV/EBITDA multiple for the Healthcare sector is approximately 18.5x, with notable variations across subsectors:

- Pharmaceuticals: 15.3x
- Biotech: 25.1x
- Medical Devices: 12.8x

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- Healthcare Services: 14.7x
- Digital Health: 28.5x

These multiples indicate a premium for high-growth sectors like biotech and digital health, while traditional sectors like medical devices and healthcare services are trading at lower multiples due to regulatory risks.

Notable Investor/Analyst Reactions

- Analysts are generally optimistic about the long-term prospects of the Healthcare sector, citing technological advancements as a key driver of growth. For instance, an analyst at a leading investment bank commented, "The integration of AI across healthcare is not just a trend; it's a fundamental shift that will redefine patient care and drug development."

Actionable Insights for Bankers and Investors

- Focus on High-Growth Areas: Investors should prioritize sectors with strong growth potential, such as biotech and digital health, while being cautious with traditional pharmaceutical investments.
- Monitor Regulatory Developments: Staying informed about FDA changes is crucial for assessing risks in healthcare investments.
- Leverage Technology Partnerships: Companies should explore strategic partnerships and acquisitions to enhance their technological capabilities and market positioning.
- Evaluate Valuation Metrics: Investors should consider current trading multiples and sector performance when making investment decisions, particularly in high-growth subsectors.

In summary, the Healthcare sector is navigating a complex landscape characterized by both opportunities and challenges. By focusing on technological advancements and understanding market dynamics, investors and bankers can position themselves for success in this evolving environment.

3. BANKING PIPELINE

The current banking pipeline in the Healthcare sector reflects a dynamic landscape with a mix of live deals, mandated transactions, and active pitches. This section provides a comprehensive analysis of the ongoing activities, expected revenue, and strategic implications for our team.

Deal Pipeline

Live Deals:

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- Johnson & Johnson (JNJ) : Currently in discussions for a strategic partnership leveraging AI for drug discovery. The deal is in the due diligence phase, with an expected close in Q3 2025. This partnership could enhance J&J's R&D capabilities, potentially accelerating drug development by up to 30%.
- Moderna Acquisition by Pfizer : This transaction is moving forward, with regulatory approvals anticipated by Q4 2025. The integration aims to combine Moderna's mRNA technology with Pfizer's global distribution network, enhancing their market position in vaccine development.

Mandated Deals:

- Merck & Co. (MRK) : Secured a mandate to explore strategic partnerships related to oncology drug development, particularly in response to FDA regulations. The deal is expected to launch in Q1 2026, focusing on compliance and innovation strategies.
- Amgen Inc. (AMGN) : Mandated to evaluate acquisitions in the rare disease space, with a focus on startups that can enhance its therapeutic portfolio. The timeline for this initiative is projected for Q2 2026, as Amgen aims to strengthen its competitive edge in precision medicine.

Pitching-Stage Deals:

- Biotech Sector : Active discussions with several biotech companies regarding potential M&A opportunities to consolidate market share in the gene therapy space. Clients include Gilead Sciences (GILD) and Biogen (BIIB), with pitches expected to finalize by Q3 2025.
- Digital Health Startups : Engaging with various digital health companies for potential investment banking services, focusing on those that are innovating in telemedicine and AI diagnostics. Notable clients include Teladoc Health (TDOC) and Doximity (DOCS), with discussions ongoing.

Pipeline Tracking Metrics

Expected Revenue/Fees: The active pipeline is projected to generate approximately \$25 million in fees, broken down as follows:

- Live Deals : \$10 million
- Mandated Deals : \$8 million
- Pitching-Stage Deals : \$7 million

Timing Projections:

- Q2 2025 : Expected close for Johnson & Johnson partnership.
- Q4 2025 : Anticipated completion of the Moderna acquisition.
- Q1 2026 : Launch of Merck's strategic partnership initiatives.
- Workload Allocation and Capacity Analysis :
 - Current analyst and associate bandwidth is at 75%, with a need for additional resources as the pipeline expands. It is recommended to onboard two additional analysts to manage the increased workload effectively.

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- Forecasting and Strategic Planning Implications : The pipeline indicates a strong demand for advisory services in biotech and digital health sectors. Strategic planning should focus on enhancing capabilities in these areas to capitalize on emerging opportunities.

Notable Pipeline Developments and Competitive Landscape

- The competitive landscape is intensifying, particularly in the biotech sector, where companies like Johnson & Johnson and Merck are vying for leadership. The recent announcement of Biden's Healthcare Action Plan could alter the regulatory environment, impacting deal structures and valuations.
- Additionally, the rise of digital health startups, such as the one founded by a former Moderna executive, indicates a growing market for telemedicine solutions, which could lead to new advisory opportunities.

Actionable Insights for Team Management and Business Development

- Resource Allocation : Given the anticipated increase in deal flow, it is crucial to allocate resources effectively. Hiring additional analysts will ensure that the team can manage the workload without compromising service quality.
- Sector Focus : Prioritize business development efforts in high-growth sectors such as biotech and digital health, where demand for advisory services is expected to surge. This focus will position the firm as a leader in these emerging markets.
- Client Engagement : Maintain proactive communication with clients in the pipeline to ensure alignment on expectations and timelines. Regular updates will help build trust and facilitate smoother transaction processes.

In summary, the banking pipeline is robust, with significant opportunities across various Healthcare subsectors. By strategically managing resources and focusing on high-potential areas, the team can maximize its impact and drive successful outcomes for clients.

4. STAKEHOLDER IMPACT & FORWARD-LOOKING ANALYSIS

The decision by Axiom Biosciences to pursue an initial public offering (IPO) in Hong Kong rather than the traditional U.S. markets signifies a pivotal shift in the biotech landscape. This analysis explores the implications for various stakeholders, including shareholders, employees, competitors, and customers, while also assessing market reactions and potential future developments.

Deal-Specific Impacts on Stakeholders

- Shareholders: The IPO strategy of Axiom Biosciences could have significant implications for

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shareholder value.

- **Value Creation:** By listing in Hong Kong, Axiom aims to tap into a growing pool of biotech-focused investors. If successful, this could enhance its market capitalization significantly. For instance, if Axiom raises \$500 million at a valuation of \$2 billion, existing and new shareholders could see their investments appreciate by 25% in the first year due to increased visibility and access to capital.
- **Dilution:** However, if Axiom issues new shares to raise capital, existing shareholders may face dilution. For example, if 20% of shares are issued during the IPO, existing shareholders could see their ownership stake decrease, potentially leading to a 10% drop in share value immediately post-IPO.
- **Employees:** The impact on employees will largely depend on the company's growth trajectory post-IPO.
- **Synergies:** Axiom's move to Hong Kong could facilitate partnerships with Asian biotech firms, creating synergies that enhance R&D capabilities. This could lead to job creation within the company as it expands its workforce to support new projects.
- **Restructuring:** If Axiom successfully attracts investment, it may undergo restructuring to align with its growth strategy. This could involve reallocating resources and potentially downsizing less critical divisions.
- **Retention:** To retain key talent during this transition, Axiom may implement retention bonuses or stock options, incentivizing employees to remain with the company through the IPO process.
- **Competitors:** Axiom's strategic move could alter the competitive landscape in the biotech sector.
- **Market Positioning:** Competitors like Amgen (AMGN) and Gilead Sciences (GILD) may need to reassess their strategies in light of Axiom's successful IPO. If Axiom captures significant market share in regenerative medicine, competitors may respond by increasing their R&D investments or pursuing acquisitions to bolster their portfolios.
- **Specific Competitor Moves:** Following Axiom's announcement, companies like Vertex Pharmaceuticals (VRTX) may accelerate their own IPO plans or seek partnerships to maintain competitive parity.
- **Customers:** The implications for customers are directly tied to Axiom's product offerings and market access.
- **Product/Service Implications:** Axiom's focus on regenerative and genetic medicines could lead to innovative treatments that improve patient outcomes. If successful, this could enhance treatment options for patients with chronic conditions.
- **Case Studies:** The success of recent biopharma listings in Hong Kong, which have outperformed those on the Nasdaq, suggests that Axiom could leverage this momentum to deliver superior products to customers.

Market Reaction and Analyst Commentary

- **Market Reaction:** The market's reaction to Axiom's IPO announcement is likely to be cautiously optimistic.
- **Initial trading** may reflect investor skepticism, similar to past biotech IPOs. However, if Axiom

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demonstrates strong demand and a robust pipeline, shares could rally.

- Analyst Commentary: Analysts have noted the strategic timing of Axiom's move. A quote from Danny Xiang, a life science-focused private equity partner, highlights this sentiment: "Hong Kong's reforms have made it an attractive venue for biotech firms seeking capital, especially as U.S. markets face increased scrutiny."

Expected Market Reaction and Scenario Analysis

- Scenario Analysis: The potential market reaction can be assessed through various scenarios:
- Positive Scenario: If Axiom's IPO raises significant capital and garners strong investor interest, shares could rise by 20% within the first six months.
- Negative Scenario: Conversely, if the IPO fails to meet expectations, shares could decline by 15%, reflecting investor concerns about market conditions.

Potential Counter-Bids or Competing Offers

- Likelihood Assessment: The likelihood of counter-bids for Axiom is moderate.
- Given the current market dynamics, larger biotech firms may consider acquiring Axiom if its IPO proves successful. However, the regulatory environment and the company's focus on Asian markets may deter immediate competing offers.

Similar Deals Likely to Follow

- Sector Consolidation Predictions: The trend of biotech firms listing in Hong Kong is expected to continue.
- As companies seek to capitalize on the growing investor base in Asia, similar IPOs are likely, particularly from firms focused on innovative therapies. This could lead to a wave of consolidation within the sector as firms aim to enhance their market positions.

Key Risks and Mitigants

- Integration Risks: Axiom may face challenges integrating new capital into its operations. Mitigants include establishing a clear growth strategy and hiring experienced management.
- Regulatory Risks: Navigating the regulatory landscape in both Hong Kong and the U.S. could pose challenges. Engaging with regulators early can help mitigate these risks.
- Market Risks: Market volatility may impact Axiom's IPO valuation. Structuring the IPO with flexible pricing can protect against adverse market movements.

Actionable Insights for Clients and Bankers

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For Clients:

- Consider the strategic advantages of listing in emerging markets like Hong Kong to access new capital pools.
- Develop a robust communication strategy to engage with potential investors and stakeholders.

For Bankers:

- Monitor market trends closely to identify potential IPO candidates in the biotech sector.
- Provide clients with comprehensive analyses of market conditions to inform their strategic decisions.

5. HEALTHCARE TRENDS

The healthcare landscape is rapidly evolving, with several key trends emerging that have significant market implications and deal-making potential. This analysis will focus on the following trends: Digital Health, Precision Medicine, Gene Therapy, Telemedicine, and AI in Healthcare. Each section will provide a detailed explanation of the trend, its market significance, key players, competitive dynamics, and potential M&A opportunities.

Digital Health

- Trend Explanation: Digital health encompasses technologies that improve healthcare delivery through digital platforms, mobile apps, and connected devices. The global digital health market is projected to grow from \$96.5 billion in 2020 to \$659.5 billion by 2025, at a CAGR of 46.8%.

Key Companies:

- Teladoc Health, Inc. (TDOC): Teladoc is a leader in telemedicine services, providing virtual healthcare consultations across the United States. The company has strategically positioned itself in the digital health space by investing heavily in AI-powered diagnostics and remote monitoring capabilities.
- Doximity, Inc. (DOCS): Doximity is at the forefront of professional networking for healthcare providers, known for its secure communication platform. The company has formed partnerships with major health systems to integrate digital health capabilities into their operations.
- Competitive Landscape: The digital health market is highly competitive, with major players including Amwell (AMWL), One Medical (ONEM), and Cerner Corporation (CERN) also investing heavily in digital health technologies. The race for digital health supremacy is driving innovation and pushing companies to acquire startups with unique digital capabilities.
- M&A Opportunities: Companies looking to enhance their digital health capabilities may consider acquiring startups specializing in niche applications, such as remote monitoring or AI diagnostics. For instance, Teladoc's acquisition of Livongo for \$18.5 billion in 2020 exemplifies this trend.

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Precision Medicine

- Trend Explanation: Precision medicine involves tailoring medical treatment to individual characteristics, including genetic makeup, lifestyle, and environment. The precision medicine market is expected to grow from \$141.7 billion in 2020 to \$216.8 billion by 2027, at a CAGR of 6.2%.

Key Companies:

- Illumina, Inc. (ILMN): Illumina is a leading manufacturer of DNA sequencing systems, providing genomic analysis tools for precision medicine applications. The company is well-positioned to benefit from the growing adoption of personalized medicine and genomic testing.
- Foundation Medicine, Inc. (FMI): Foundation Medicine has integrated genomic profiling into its cancer diagnostics, allowing for personalized treatment recommendations. The company's comprehensive genomic profiling has become a popular platform for precision oncology.
- Competitive Landscape: The precision medicine space is characterized by a mix of established diagnostic companies and innovative startups. Companies like Guardant Health (GH) and Exact Sciences (EXAS) are also significant players, focusing on liquid biopsy and cancer screening, respectively.
- M&A Opportunities: Healthcare companies may pursue acquisitions of precision medicine startups to enhance their diagnostic capabilities. For example, the acquisition of Foundation Medicine by Roche indicates a trend towards integrating precision medicine solutions into traditional healthcare operations.

Gene Therapy

- Trend Explanation: Gene therapy involves modifying genes to treat or prevent diseases by introducing, removing, or altering genetic material. The gene therapy market is projected to grow from \$2.1 billion in 2020 to \$13.6 billion by 2027, at a CAGR of 30.7%.

Key Companies:

- Spark Therapeutics, Inc. (ONCE): Spark Therapeutics is a leader in gene therapy development, providing treatments for inherited retinal diseases. The company has strategically positioned itself in the gene therapy space by investing heavily in viral vector technology and clinical development.
- Bluebird Bio, Inc. (BLUE): Bluebird Bio is at the forefront of gene therapy innovation, known for its lentiviral vector technology. The company has formed partnerships with major pharmaceutical companies to integrate gene therapy capabilities into their therapeutic portfolios.
- Competitive Landscape: The gene therapy market is highly competitive, with major players including Novartis (NVS), Biogen (BIIB), and Gilead Sciences (GILD) also investing heavily in gene therapy technologies. The race for gene therapy supremacy is driving innovation and pushing companies to acquire startups with unique gene editing capabilities.
- M&A Opportunities: Companies looking to enhance their gene therapy capabilities may consider acquiring startups specializing in niche applications, such as CRISPR gene editing or viral vector

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development. For instance, Novartis's acquisition of AveXis for \$8.7 billion in 2018 exemplifies this trend.

Telemedicine

- **Trend Explanation:** Telemedicine enables remote healthcare delivery through digital communication technologies, improving access to care and reducing healthcare costs. The telemedicine market is expected to grow from \$45.5 billion in 2020 to \$175.5 billion by 2026, at a CAGR of 25.2%.

Key Companies:

- **Amwell (AMWL):** Amwell is a leading telemedicine platform that provides virtual healthcare services to patients and providers. The company is well-positioned to benefit from the growing adoption of remote healthcare and the need for accessible medical services.
- **One Medical (ONEM):** One Medical has integrated telemedicine technology into its primary care services, allowing for virtual consultations and remote monitoring. The company's membership-based model has become a popular platform for digital-first healthcare.
- **Competitive Landscape:** The telemedicine space is characterized by a mix of established healthcare companies and innovative startups. Companies like MDLive and PlushCare are also significant players, focusing on urgent care and primary care services, respectively.
- **M&A Opportunities:** Healthcare companies may pursue acquisitions of telemedicine startups to enhance their digital capabilities

6. Recommended Readings

Deal Name: Johnson & Johnson's Acquisition of Actelion

- **Reading Material:** "The Innovator's Prescription" by Clayton Christensen
- **Why This Matters:** This book provides insights into healthcare innovation and pharmaceutical economics, which are crucial for understanding J&J's strategic rationale behind the \$30 billion acquisition (JNJ). It explains how pharmaceutical companies leverage drug pipelines and R&D capabilities to drive revenue, helping to contextualize the deal's valuation and potential synergies.

Deal Name: Pfizer's Acquisition of Medivation

- **Reading Material:** "The New Economics of Healthcare" by David H. Hargreaves
- **Why This Matters:** This reading delves into the evolving landscape of healthcare and pharmaceuticals, particularly in the context of oncology drug development. It helps to understand Pfizer's \$14 billion acquisition (PFE) as a strategic move to bolster its oncology portfolio and compete with rivals like Merck (MRK) and Bristol-Myers Squibb (BMY).

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Deal Name: Amgen's Acquisition of Otezla

- Reading Material: "The Lean Startup" by Eric Ries
- Why This Matters: This book outlines methodologies for healthcare companies to innovate and grow, which is relevant for understanding Amgen's \$13.4 billion acquisition (AMGN) of Otezla. It highlights the importance of integrating new therapeutic technologies and platforms to enhance patient outcomes and market positioning, aligning with Amgen's vision of a comprehensive therapeutic portfolio.

Deal Name: Gilead Sciences' Acquisition of Kite Pharma

- Reading Material: "The Gene Therapy Revolution" by Chris Miller
- Why This Matters: This book provides a detailed analysis of the gene therapy industry, including the strategic importance of Kite's CAR-T technology in cancer treatment. Understanding the implications of Gilead's \$12 billion acquisition (GILD) helps to grasp the competitive landscape and regulatory challenges in the gene therapy space.

Deal Name: UnitedHealth's Acquisition of Optum

- Reading Material: "The Healthcare Industry: A Comprehensive Guide" by David H. Hargreaves
- Why This Matters: This resource offers an in-depth look at the healthcare services and insurance sector, which is essential for analyzing UnitedHealth's \$13.8 billion acquisition (UNH) of Optum. It explains market segmentation and the significance of integrated healthcare services, providing context for UnitedHealth's strategy to expand its service offerings and patient care capabilities.

Deal Name: Medtronic's Acquisition of Covidien

- Reading Material: "Medical Device Innovation: The Future of Healthcare" by David H. Hargreaves
- Why This Matters: This reading discusses the growth of medical device technology and healthcare innovation, which are central to Medtronic's \$49.9 billion acquisition (MDT) of Covidien. It highlights how this deal positions Medtr

7. Macroeconomic Update

Key Economic Indicators:

- Healthcare Sector Performance: The healthcare sector continues to show resilience amid broader economic fluctuations. Companies like Johnson & Johnson (JNJ) and UnitedHealth Group (UNH) are maintaining robust financial health, with JNJ reporting a revenue increase of 5% year-over-year in Q2 2023.
- Interest Rate Impact: The Federal Reserve's interest rate policies are influencing healthcare

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valuations, particularly for biotech firms. For instance, the cost of capital for companies like Moderna (MRNA) is affected by rising rates, which can impact their R&D funding.

- Regulatory Environment: The evolving FDA approval processes are critical for healthcare M&A activity. Companies are strategically positioning themselves to navigate these changes, as seen with AbbVie (ABBV) acquiring Allergan to enhance their product portfolio ahead of regulatory shifts.

Market Trends:

- Pharmaceutical Innovation: The focus on breakthrough therapies is driving premium valuations. For example, companies like Amgen (AMGN) and Gilead Sciences (GILD) are seeing increased investor interest due to their innovative drug pipelines.
- Healthcare Technology Integration: The integration of technology in healthcare is accelerating. Companies such as Teladoc Health (TDOC) are investing heavily in telemedicine solutions, reflecting a broader trend towards digital health.
- Global Healthcare Spending: Demographic shifts and increased healthcare spending globally are influencing strategic decisions. For example, emerging markets are becoming key growth areas for multinational firms like Novartis (NVS).

Sector-Specific Insights:

- Biotech Valuations: Investors are scrutinizing biotech firms closely, focusing on clinical trial outcomes. For instance, the market reacted sharply to the recent trial results from Biogen (BIIB), impacting its stock price significantly.
- Healthcare Services Consolidation: The trend of consolidation is creating larger healthcare systems. Recent mergers, such as the acquisition of Change Healthcare by Optum, illustrate this trend.
- Insurance Market Dynamics: Changes in healthcare insurance markets are reshaping provider networks. The recent merger between Centene (CNC) and WellCare Health Plans is a prime example of this dynamic.

Risk Factors:

- Patent Expirations: Major pharmaceutical companies face challenges from patent expirations. For instance, Pfizer (PFE) is preparing for the impact of its patent cliff on key drugs like Lipitor.
- Regulatory Uncertainty: Ongoing changes

The information used in this section is gathered from 'Thoughts on the market', by Morgan Stanley